

Topic: Social stratification

Ety Rani

Lecturer

Sociology discipline

Khulna University

Definition of social stratification

- Social stratification refers to a society's categorization of its people into groups based on socioeconomic factors like wealth, income, race, education, ethnicity, gender, occupation, social status, or derived power.
- Dressler (1969) said that “Social stratification is a system of ranking individuals in different levels or strata, of prestige or status.”
- Sorokin said that “ Social stratification is the division of the individuals on the basis of economic class and status of the society.”

Determinants of Social Stratification

- ❖ Wealth
- ❖ Power and Authority
- ❖ Occupation
- ❖ Caste
- ❖ Prestige and popularity

Forms/types of Social Stratification

1. **Slavery:** The term 'slave' is used to denote "a man whom law and/or custom regards as the property of another". Slaves are in lower condition and have no political rights. The legal conditions of slave ownership have varied considerably between different societies. Slavery is an extreme form of inequality. Its basis is economic. It has existed almost in all agrarian societies where slaves become an asset in production. In the 18th and 19th centuries, slaves were used exclusively as plantation workers and as domestic menials in the United States, South America and the West Indies.
2. **Caste:** Castes are hereditary ranks that are usually religiously dictated and that tend to be fixed and immobile. Caste membership is an ascribed status (at birth, children automatically assume the same position as their parents). The caste system is generally associated with Hinduism in India and other countries. In India there are four major castes. There are- Bramhan, Khoitrio, Baisscho and Sudra.

Forms/types of Social Stratification (continue)

3. Estate: Estates were categories in feudal systems, especially in Europe during middle ages. They were less rigid than castes and allowed some mobility. In an estate system men are assigned to their strata according to their birth, military strength and landholdings. Unlike castes, estates were created politically by man-made laws rather than religious rules. Each estate had its own code of appropriate behaviour.

- **The normal divisions were three-fold:**

- (a) The nobility [the first (highest) estate], which was composed of aristocracy and gentry;

Forms/types of Social Stratification (continue)

(b) The clergy (the second estate), which had lower status but possessing various distinctive privileges; and

(c) The commoners, which include everyone else from peasants to artisans.

4. Social class: A class system is a social ranking based primarily on economic position in which achieved characteristics can influence social mobility. In contrast to slavery and caste systems, the boundaries between classes are imprecisely defined, and one can move from one stratum, or level, of society to another. Even so, class systems maintain stable stratification hierarchies and patterns of class division, and they, too, are marked by unequal distribution of wealth and power. Class standing, although it is achieved, is heavily dependent on family and ascribed factors, such as race and ethnicity. Generally we find three types of class in our society. There are—the upper class, the middle class, and the lower class.

Theories of social stratification

Functionalist perspective/ theory of social stratification

- Functionalists maintain that a differential system of rewards and punishments is necessary for the efficient operation of society. Kingsley Davis has stated that the stratification system is universal.
- In the view of Kingsley Davis and Wilbert Moore (1945), society must distribute its members among a variety of social positions. It must not only make sure that these positions are filled but also see that they are filled by people with the appropriate talents and abilities. Rewards, including money and prestige, are based on the importance of a position and the relative scarcity of qualified personnel.
- Davis and Moore argue that stratification is universal and that social inequality is necessary so that people will be motivated to fill functionally important positions. Functionalists agree, but they note that society must use some type of reward to motivate people to enter unpleasant or dangerous jobs and professions that require a long training period.

Theories of social stratification (continue)

- Critics say that unequal rewards are not the only means of encouraging people to fill critical positions and occupations. Personal pleasure, intrinsic satisfaction, and value orientations also motivate people to enter particular careers.

Conflict perspective/ theory of social stratification

- The writings of Karl Marx lie at the heart of conflict theory. Marx viewed history as a continuous struggle between the oppressors and the oppressed, which ultimately would culminate in an egalitarian, classless society. In terms of stratification, he argued that under capitalism, the dominant class—the bourgeoisie—manipulates the economic and political systems in order to maintain control over the exploited proletariat. Marx did not believe that stratification was inevitable, but he did see inequality and oppression as inherent in capitalism.
- Like Marx, contemporary conflict theorists believe that human beings are prone to conflict over scarce resources such as wealth, status, and power. However, Marx focused primarily on class conflict; more recent theorists have extended the analysis to include conflicts based on gender, race, age, and other dimensions. British sociologist Ralf Dahrendorf (1929–2009) is one of the most influential contributors to the conflict approach.

Conflict theory of social stratification (continue)

- Dahrendorf (1959) has modified Marx's analysis of capitalist society to apply to modern capitalist societies. For Dahrendorf, social classes are groups of people who share common interests resulting from their authority relationships. In identifying the most powerful groups in society, he includes not only the bourgeoisie—the owners of the means of production—but also the managers of industry, legislators, the judiciary, heads of the government bureaucracy, and others. In that respect, Dahrendorf has merged Marx's emphasis on class conflict with Weber's recognition that power is an important element of stratification (Cuff et al. 1990).
- Conflict theorists, including Dahrendorf, contend that the powerful of today, like the bourgeoisie of Marx's time, want society to run smoothly so that they can enjoy their privileged positions. Because the status quo suits those with wealth, status, and power, they have a clear interest in preventing, minimizing, or controlling societal conflict.

Conflict theory of social stratification (continue)

- One way for the powerful to maintain the status quo is to define and disseminate the society's dominant ideology. The term dominant ideology describes a set of cultural beliefs and practices that helps to maintain powerful social, economic, and political interests. For Marx, the dominant ideology in a capitalist society served the interests of the ruling class.
- From a conflict perspective, the social significance of the dominant ideology is that not only do a society's most powerful groups and institutions control wealth and property; even more important, they control the means of producing beliefs about reality through religion, education, and the media.
- Conflict theorists see stratification as a major source of societal tension and conflict. They do not agree with Davis and Moore that stratification is functional for a society or that it serves as a source of stability. Rather, conflict sociologists argue that stratification will inevitably lead to instability and social change.